From Stone to Smartphone: Phase 4 Submission

How Information Has Travelled Across India

UPDH Course Project, Phase 4: Develop Text and Promotional Material

Team ChronoScribes

- Akula Harsha Vardhan
- Santhosh
- Bhanu Prakash
- Nikhil Mohan Chowdary
- Sangameshwar

1. Introductory Panel (Entrance)

FROM STONE TO SMARTPHONE

How Information Has Travelled Across India

Every message you have ever received, a voice note, a forwarded photo, a school notice, travelled to you by some route. This exhibition follows those routes across India.

We begin with speech and carved stone. Then we follow handwritten letters and messengers, printed newspapers, the telegraph and telephone, radio and television, and finally the networks in your pocket. At each stop, ask four questions: How fast did the message travel? How many people did it reach? Who could use it? Could you trust it?

You will see that new technology rarely replaced the old completely. It changed who could speak and who could listen, but it never gave everyone equal access. Cost, literacy, language and distance always decided who was left out.

Follow the numbered route, touch only the objects marked for handling, and try the four activities in the last zone. The Future of Communication Wall and the visitors' book are yours to fill. Your words become part of this exhibition.

When information can reach millions of people in seconds, how do we decide what deserves to be believed?

A note from the curators: our team chose what to show here, and we could not show everything. Many regional languages, oral traditions and local communication practices are not on these walls. Tell us what we missed.

Scan for the digital companion to this exhibition: [QR CODE 0]

2. Zone 1: Early Communication

Section 1: Before the Written Message

How do you send a message to people you will never meet?

Before writing, messages lived in voices, gestures and memory. Songs, stories and spoken traditions carried knowledge from one generation to the next. But a spoken message travelled only as far as the speaker, and it could change with every retelling.

Then people began to make marks. The seals of the Indus (Harappan) civilisation carry symbols that scholars have not been able to decipher. We do not know what they say, and this exhibition does not pretend to. Much later, around the 3rd century BCE, the emperor Ashoka had messages carved on rocks and pillars in different parts of the subcontinent. Stone made a message public, fixed and long-lasting.

But stone also had limits. Only people who could read the script, or who heard it read aloud, could receive the message. And it was the ruler who chose what was written.

Look closer: *Why would a ruler carve a message in stone instead of telling people one by one?*

Try it: Visit Decode the Symbol in Zone 4.

Scan to see the evidence: Ashokan edicts and Indus seals **[QR CODE 1]**

Labels

1.1 Ashokan Edict (printed image)

Date: Around 3rd century BCE (original)

Description: A printed photograph of an inscribed stone pillar.

Story: Ashoka had messages carved on rocks and pillars so that many people could see them. Stone preserved the words, but only some people could read them.

1.2 Indus Seal (handmade clay replica)

Date: Original seals from the Indus civilisation; replica made by the ChronoScribes team, 2026

Description: A clay copy of a small stamp seal with symbols.

Story: Nobody has yet been able to read the Indus script. We do not know what these symbols say, so we do not claim a meaning.

1.3 Oral Tradition (printed image)

Date: A living tradition across many centuries

Description: An image of people sharing a story or message by speaking.

Story: Before writing, and long after it, communities kept stories, songs and knowledge alive by telling them aloud and remembering them.

Section 2: Messages on the Move

What happens when a message has to travel on foot, on horseback or by hand?

Longer texts were copied by hand onto palm leaf, birch bark and other materials. Each copy took time and skill, and each copy could carry small changes.

To send a message across distance, rulers and officials relied on runners, horse couriers and relay posts. Letters, administrative orders and intelligence moved along organised routes, often called dak routes. Over time, postal systems carried not only official orders but also personal letters, connecting families and communities that lived far apart.

Yet every message still depended on a person physically carrying it. Speed depended on distance, weather and roads. And the post served some people better than others: those who could write, who could afford to send, and who lived along a route.

The stamps on display show how a small piece of paper recorded that a message had been paid for and sent.

Look closer: *Who would have been able to send a letter in this system, and who would not?*

Try it: Trace a dak route on the map, then look at the sample letter and envelope.

Scan to explore postal history: Postal routes, stamps and letters **[QR CODE 2]**

Labels

2.1 Palm-Leaf Style Manuscript (replica)

Date: Replica made 2026; the practice of writing on palm leaf is many centuries old

Description: Text written by hand on dried leaf, made by the team.

Story: Texts were copied by hand, one copy at a time. Each copy took skill and time, and small changes could creep in.

2.2 Dak Route Map (printed)

Date: Map reproduced for this exhibition, 2026

Description: A map showing postal and courier routes.

Story: Runners and relay posts carried orders and letters along set routes. Places far from a route received news later or not at all.

2.3 Stamps (collected by the team)

Date: Various years

Description: Postage stamps, old and recent.

Story: A stamp shows that the sender has paid for a letter to travel. It also shows what images a country chose to put on its mail.

2.4 Sample Letter and Envelope

Date: Prepared for this exhibition, 2026

Description: A handwritten letter with its envelope.

Story: A personal letter could take days or weeks to arrive. Writing, waiting and replying shaped how people kept in touch.

3. Zone 2: Print and Electric Signals

Section 3: One Message, Many Readers

What changes when the same words can be copied a thousand times?

Printing made it possible to produce many identical copies of a text. The first printing press in India was set up in Goa in 1556. Over time, books, pamphlets and newspapers carried news and opinion to larger audiences.

One early example is Hicky's Bengal Gazette, which began publication in Calcutta in 1780. Newspapers like this allowed readers to see the same reports and to argue about them in public.

But printing did not reach everyone equally. A printed page still had to be physically delivered. And a reader needed to know the language and to be able to read at all. Compare the handwritten and printed samples on display: printing made text uniform and repeatable, but it did not decide who could read it.

Printed words also carried the views of those who owned the press and chose what to publish.

Look closer: *Who decided what went into an early newspaper, and who is missing from its pages?*

Scan to read an early newspaper: Hicky's Bengal Gazette and the history of printing in India **[QR CODE 3]**

Labels

3.1 Hicky's Bengal Gazette (printout)

Date: 1780

Description: A printed copy of an early newspaper from Calcutta.

Story: Newspapers let many readers see the same news at once. Only people who could read that language and reach a copy could join in.

3.2 Handwritten and Printed Text Samples

Date: Made by the ChronoScribes team, 2026

Description: The same sentence written by hand and printed.

Story: Printing made many identical copies easy. Handwriting varies from one copy to the next. Compare the two.

Section 4: Signals Across Distance

What if a message could travel faster than any messenger?

The electric telegraph sent coded signals along wires. In India, an experimental line between Calcutta and Diamond Harbour was tried in 1850, and telegraph service began operating in 1851. Messages were sent in Morse code, a system of dots and dashes that turned words into signals.

For the first time, a message could outrun a person. But the telegraph needed wires, stations and trained operators, so it reached only places that were connected. Messages were short and often costly.

The telephone added something new: a live human voice. Telephone exchanges began to appear in Indian cities in 1882. Calls needed connected lines and equipment, so access depended on where you lived and what you could afford.

Text versus voice, coded versus spoken: each system changed how people shared urgent news.

Look closer: *Who could afford to send a telegram, and what kinds of news would they send?*

Try it: Visit Crack the Code in Zone 4 and send a word in dots and dashes.

Scan to learn more: The Indian telegraph and how Morse code works **[QR CODE 4]**

Labels

4.1 Telegraph Diagram (printed)

Date: Diagram reproduced for this exhibition, 2026

Description: A diagram of how a telegraph sends signals along a wire.

Story: A telegraph operator tapped out coded signals that travelled instantly along wires. It was fast, but it only worked between connected stations.

4.2 Morse Code Chart

Date: 19th century system

Description: A chart showing each letter as dots and dashes.

Story: Morse code turned words into short and long signals so they could travel by wire. You can try it in Crack the Code.

4.3 Telephone (borrowed)

Date: Landline model lent for this exhibition

Description: An old landline telephone.

Story: The telephone carried a live voice. Exchanges connected callers, but a home needed a line, and many homes did not have one.

4. Zone 3: Mass and Digital Communication

Section 5: Broadcasting to Large Audiences

What if one voice could reach millions at the same time?

Radio carried sound through the air to many receivers at once. Radio broadcasting began in India in the 1920s, and the national broadcaster later became All India Radio. Television added moving pictures, and experimental television broadcasting began in India in 1959. Satellite systems later helped broadcasts reach far larger areas, and India's INSAT satellite series began in the 1980s.

Broadcasting made it possible to share announcements, news and shared events with huge audiences, even people who could not read. That mattered in a country with many languages and many levels of literacy.

But traditional broadcasting was mainly one-way. Listeners received; they could not easily reply. And a few institutions decided what was broadcast, in which language and at what time.

Look closer: *Who spoke on early radio, and who only listened?*

Scan to listen and learn: All India Radio, Doordarshan and the INSAT satellites **[QR CODE 5]**

Labels

5.1 Radio Model (cardboard)

Date: Model made 2026; radio broadcasting began in India in the 1920s

Description: A cardboard model of a vintage radio.

Story: Radio let one broadcaster speak to many homes at once, including people who could not read.

5.2 Television Model (cardboard)

Date: Model made 2026; experimental television in India began in 1959

Description: A cardboard model of an early television set.

Story: Television added moving pictures. Like radio, it mostly sent information one way, from broadcaster to viewer.

5.3 INSAT Satellite (papercraft or diagram)

Date: Model made 2026; the INSAT series began in the 1980s

Description: A folded paper model of an Indian communication satellite.

Story: Satellites help send signals across very large areas, including places that are hard to reach by wire.

Section 6: Networks in Everyone's Hands

When everyone can send, who decides what is true?

Digital systems turn information into data and send it across connected networks. Computers, optical fibre, mobile networks and smartphones power email, websites, messaging, video calls and social media. Public internet service began in India in 1995.

For the first time, many people can be both senders and receivers, and a message can reach thousands in moments. This is many-to-many communication.

But speed is not truth. False claims travel as quickly as true ones, and artificial intelligence tools can translate, summarise and create text without guaranteeing that it is accurate. Access is also uneven: it depends on devices, data costs, electricity, language and skills.

So the old questions return in a new form. Who made this message? When? What is the evidence? Does another reliable source confirm it?

Try it: Visit Which Source Would You Trust? and the Future of Communication Wall in Zone 4.

Scan to check before you share: Verifying information online **[QR CODE 6]**

Labels

6.1 Phone and Laptop

Date: Everyday devices of today

Description: Devices that connect to digital networks.

Story: These devices can send a message across the world in seconds. They also need data, power and skills that not everyone has equal access to.

6.2 Network Diagram (printed)

Date: Diagram reproduced for this exhibition, 2026

Description: A diagram showing how devices link through a network.

Story: Information is broken into small packets that travel through connected networks and are put back together at the other end.

6.3 Digital Information Examples (printed screenshots)

Date: Screenshots taken for this exhibition, 2026

Description: Printed examples of messages, websites and posts.

Story: Anyone can post online. Check who wrote it, when, and whether other reliable sources agree.

5. Zone 4: Interactive Activities

Decode the Symbol.

Look at the Ashokan edict and the Indus seal. Use the clue card to discuss: why would someone carve or stamp a message? Remember: nobody can yet read the Indus script, so we only discuss, we do not translate.

Crack the Code.

Pick a word card (HELP, INDIA or HISTORY). Use the Morse chart to turn it into dots and dashes. Swap with a friend and decode theirs.

Which Source Would You Trust?

You receive the same news from a newspaper, a broadcast, a website and a social media forward. Which would you check first? Look for the source, the date, the evidence and confirmation from other reliable sources.

Future of Communication Wall.

How will people in India communicate in 2050? Write your answer on a sticky note and add it to the wall. Think about who will have access and who might not.

6. Main Attraction: Experience the Evolution of Communication

Our main attraction is to let visitors experience how information travelled across India, from ancient inscriptions and handwritten messages to modern smartphones and digital networks. Through interactive activities such as decoding ancient symbols, cracking Morse code and testing the reliability of information, visitors will not just observe history but actively participate in it. The exhibition will connect India's communication past with the technologies we use today and encourage visitors to imagine the future of communication.

7. Promotional Material

The proposed promotional materials will include:

- **Main Exhibition Poster:** Promoting the title, theme, exhibition sections, interactive activities, date, venue and time.
- **Section Posters:** Small posters introducing the six stages of communication history.
- **Digital Promotion:** Sharing the exhibition poster through WhatsApp groups, college communities and social media platforms.

Poster

CAN YOU SEND HELP IN DOTS AND DASHES?

FROM STONE TO SMARTPHONE

How has information travelled across India?

Crack a Morse code message · Puzzle over a mystery seal · Decide which news to trust · Predict how we will communicate in 2050

A pop-up museum by Team ChronoScribes

When: [Date and time] **Where:** [Venue and room]

Scan to see what is inside: **[QR CODE 0]**

Current poster draft: https://drive.google.com/file/d/150gfottq4M4yl2yYkBd0vvolY2rgd6Zl/view?usp=sharing

Flyer

YOUR PHONE HAS A VERY LONG FAMILY TREE.

See where it came from, from carved stone and handwritten letters to telegraph wires, radio waves and the internet.

Try it: send a secret message in Morse code. Test your instincts: which news source would you trust? Leave a prediction on our 2050 wall.

Short, hands-on, and open to everyone. Come for five minutes or stay for thirty.

[Date · Time · Venue] · Team ChronoScribes

Scan for a preview: **[QR CODE 0]**

8. Visitors' Book (Exit)

TELL US WHAT YOU THINK

Name (optional): _____

One thing I learned today: _____

One thing that surprised me: _____

Which source would I trust more now, and why? _____

Something missing from this exhibition that I would like to see: _____

My favourite activity (tick one):

☐ Decode the Symbol ☐ Crack the Code ☐ Which Source Would You Trust? ☐ 2050 Wall

Thank you for visiting. Your answers will help us understand what visitors learned and what we should add next time.

Note on QR Codes. QR codes will be created and integrated into the exhibition during the actual installation of the pop-up museum. They will be used to provide visitors with additional information, historical references, images and digital content related to the exhibits. The QR codes will therefore remain placeholders during the current planning and promotional design stage.